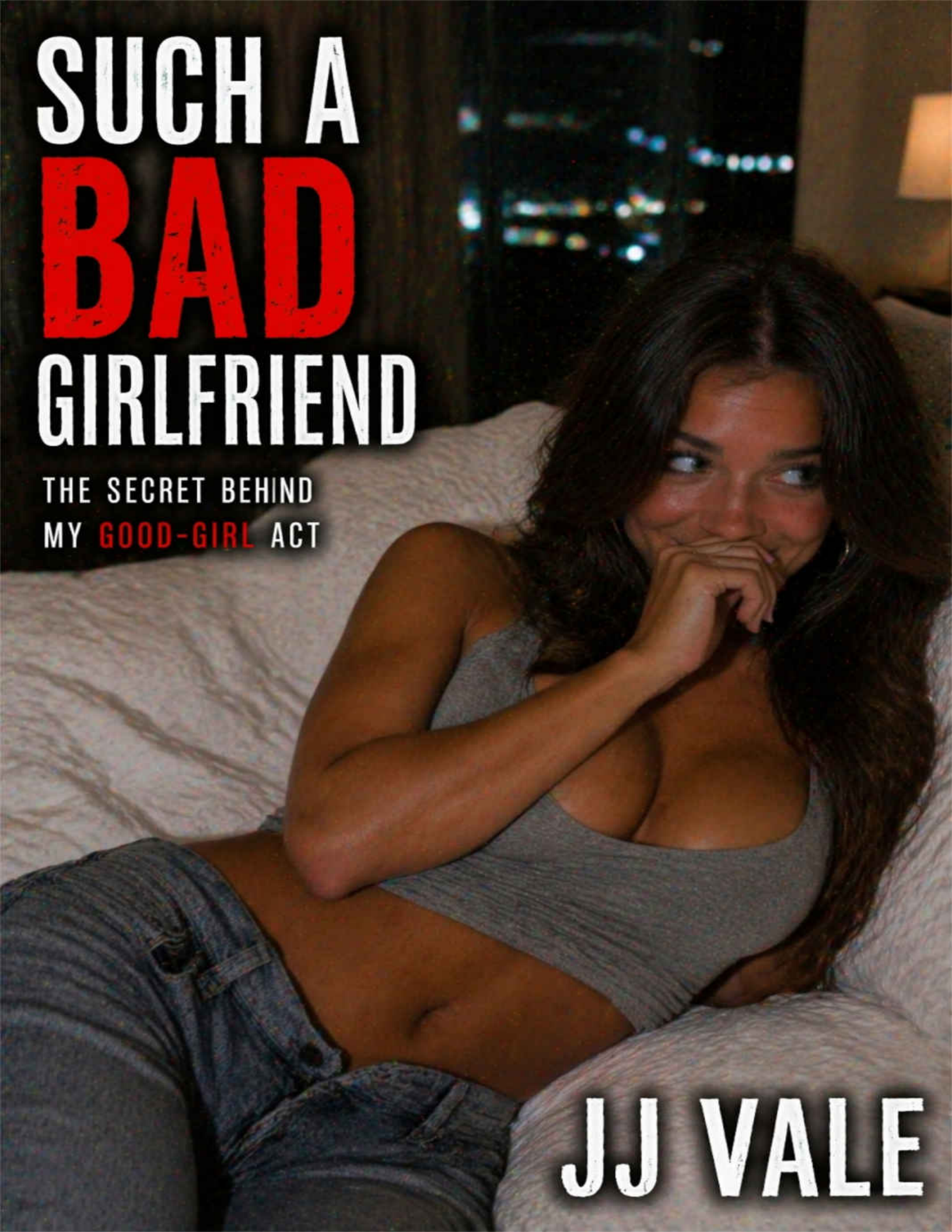




SUCH A **BAD** GIRLFRIEND

THE SECRET BEHIND
MY **GOOD-GIRL** ACT

JJ VALE

Such a Bad Girlfriend

The secret behind my good-girl act

JJ Vale

PMI

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The hotel room door clicked shut behind us and I was already pulling Brady's shirt over his head before he'd even dropped his gym bag. His skin was still warm from the workout, that clean sweat smell mixing with his cologne, and I pressed my mouth against his shoulder as his hands found my waist.

"God, you're insatiable," he breathed, laughing a little as I worked at his belt.

I didn't answer. I didn't need to. I just looked up at him through my lashes, the look that always worked, and watched his expression change from amused to hungry. His hands slid up under the silk camisole I'd worn, the emerald one that made my eyes look almost green instead of their usual hazel, and I felt that familiar thrill spike through me. The thrill that had nothing to do with him, really, and everything to do with the fact that in forty-five minutes I'd be back in my car, checking my phone for texts from Owen, probably responding to some message about what we should have for dinner.

I'm such a bad girl!

Brady pulled me toward the bed and I let myself fall back onto the crisp white duvet, watching him stand over me for a moment. He had that athlete's body, all clean lines and effortless strength, so different from Owen's softer frame. Not that Owen was unattractive, he wasn't. He was sweet-faced and gentle, with those thoughtful eyes behind his glasses, always looking at me like I was something precious he couldn't quite believe was his.

He wasn't wrong to look worried, I suppose.

"You're thinking too much," Brady said, coming down over me, his weight pressing me into the mattress.

"You know I never think," I lied, arching up to kiss him.

It was our third time meeting like this. The first had been accidental, or at least, I'd convinced myself it was. We'd been talking after a training session

at the rock climbing gym where he worked as an instructor and I'd been taking intermediate classes for the past two months. Owen had encouraged me to find a hobby, something active, saying it would be good for my stress levels. He'd even paid for the membership as an early birthday gift, bundled with new climbing shoes that were still barely broken in.

But the second time with Brady hadn't been an accident at all.

I'd texted him on a Wednesday afternoon, something casual about technique tips, and within six messages we'd been exchanging photos. Within twenty, we'd been making plans. He'd suggested his place, but I'd vetoed that immediately. Hotels were cleaner, simpler. No roommates, no neighbors, no evidence.

Now his mouth was on my neck, my collarbone, trailing lower, and I closed my eyes and let sensation take over. This was what I came for. Not connection, I had that at home, and probably too much of it, to be totally honest. Owen always wanting to talk about feelings and future plans and whether I was happy. This was something else entirely. This was the edge of something dark and glittering, the feeling of getting away with something, of being someone Owen or anybody would never recognize.

My phone buzzed in my purse across the room. Brady didn't notice, too focused on unhooking my bra, but I heard it. Probably Owen, texting about whether I wanted Thai or Indian for takeout, or sending me some article about climate change or artificial intelligence or whatever he'd fallen down a research hole about today.

Sweet, brilliant Owen, who could probably calculate the trajectory of a satellite but couldn't see what was landing right in front of him.

The thought should have made me feel guilty. Instead, it made me feel powerful. Does that make me bad?

Brady's hand slid up my thigh, pushing my skirt higher, and I made a small sound that was part act, part genuine reaction. He was good at this, confident in a way that came from a long string of successes, and I let myself sink into it, into being desired in a way so uncomplicated, so physical.

"You're so fucking beautiful," he murmured against my skin, and I smiled.

I was beautiful. I knew it the way some people know they're smart or funny, not as arrogance, just as fact. I'd learned young how to dress to make the most of it: the right jeans that made my legs look longer, the vintage

band t-shirts that suggested I was cooler than I was, the leather jacket that gave me an edge. Today I'd worn a burgundy sundress with thin straps, the kind that looked effortless but had actually taken me twenty minutes to select, knowing I'd be peeling it off in this generic hotel room with its abstract art and blackout curtains.

We didn't take our time. We didn't talk at all. We worked up a sweat hard and fast, eyes clenched shut and bodies thrashed both ways. We went at it like we were punishing each other. It was animalistic, rushed, and thorough. We destroyed the bed, destroyed each other.

When it was over, I lay next to Brady while he caught his breath, staring up at the ceiling with its textured pattern meant to hide its imperfections. I was already thinking about the shower I'd take when I got home, the story I'd tell Owen about my climbing session running late because I'd stayed to practice on the bouldering wall.

I'd gotten good at the climbing, actually. Good enough that the lie had layers of truth to it. I could describe the routes I'd attempted, the holds that had given me trouble, even show him the chalk still dusted on my palms, if he bothered to look.

He never did, though. He just kissed my forehead and asked if I wanted to order in or cook, told me about his day at the research lab, showed me equations on his laptop that might as well have been hieroglyphics.

"Same time Friday?" Brady asked, trailing his fingers down my spine.

"Can't Friday," I said. "Owen and I have dinner with his parents."

The name slipped out before I could stop it. I felt Brady's hand pause for just a fraction of a second.

"Owen?"

"My roommate," I said smoothly, already sitting up, reaching for my clothes. "He's impossible to plan around."

Brady accepted this without question, the way men usually did when a beautiful woman gave them a simple answer.

I took my time getting dressed, making Brady watch every step of it. I knew he was watching, they always did, and I drew it out for him, stepping into my underwear slowly, fastening my bra with deliberate precision, smoothing the burgundy dress down over my hips with both hands. I caught my reflection in the mirror above the dresser and paused to admire it: hair tousled in that just-fucked way that somehow looked better than any careful styling, lips slightly swollen, a faint pink flush still visible across my chest.

I looked like exactly what I was, and the thought made me smile.

"You're something else," Brady said from the bed, propped up on one elbow, sheet pooled around his waist.

"Mm," I hummed, noncommittal, fishing my phone from my purse.

Four texts from Owen. The first three were about dinner, Thai had won, apparently, from our usual place, did I want my regular order or did I want to try something new? The fourth, sent seven minutes ago: *Hope climbing is going well! Don't push yourself too hard. Love you.*

My thumb hovered over the keyboard. I could picture him exactly as he'd been when he sent it: sitting at his desk in our apartment, probably in those gray joggers he lived in when he was home, his dark hair sticking up from running his hands through it while he worked through some problem. His monitor would be filled with code or data visualizations, coffee going cold in his favorite mug, the one with Schrödinger's cat on it that I'd bought him last Christmas. Is she or isn't she?

Just finishing up, I typed back. *Love you too.*

Three words, so easy. Muscle memory at this point.

I added a heart emoji and hit send, then checked my reflection again. My lipstick had mostly worn off, kissed away an hour ago, but I had more in my purse. I pulled out the tube, MAC Russian Red, my signature, and reapplied it carefully, pressing my lips together, checking my teeth. Perfect.

"You have to leave already?" Brady asked. He'd sat up fully now, running a hand through his own hair. Even ruffled, he looked good. Objectively, he was 1,000 times better looking than Owen. Stronger jaw, better body, that easy masculine confidence that came from being desired his whole life, a prick like him.

But that wasn't really the point, was it?

"Places to be," I said lightly, dropping the lipstick back in my bag. "You know how it is."

He didn't, actually. He thought I was some free spirit with a roommate and a flexible schedule, someone who could slip away for afternoon hotel rooms without explanation or consequence. I'd been careful to keep it that way. No details about my life, no social media connections, nothing that would give him the full picture.

I'd learned that lesson young, actually. Freshman year at college, I'd been seeing two guys at once, Dylan from marketing class and Brady (different Brady, funny coincidence) from the hockey team. I'd kept them separate for

three months before getting lazy, posting a photo that Dylan had taken at exactly the wrong moment, and the whole thing had exploded spectacularly. Screaming match in the parking lot, both of them dumping me, everyone at college knowing. Whoopsie-daisy!

I'd hated that, though. Not the guilt, I hadn't felt much of that, honestly, but the loss of control. The public humiliation. The way people had looked at me afterward, whispering, judging.

So now I was careful. Meticulous, even. Different spheres, no overlap, no evidence.

Brady got out of bed, unselfconscious in his nakedness, and came over to kiss me. I allowed it, even kissed him back, feeling his hands slide down to my ass, pulling me against him.

"Friday's really no good?" he murmured against my mouth.

"Really no good," I confirmed, pulling back. "But Tuesday. I can do Tuesday afternoon."

"Same time?"

"Make it one o'clock. I'll say I'm doing a longer session."

He grinned at that, like we were co-conspirators in something thrilling rather than something sordid. "You're trouble."

"You have no idea," I said, and I meant it more than he knew.

I grabbed my leather jacket from the chair where I'd tossed it on our way in, checked the room one more time to make sure I hadn't left anything behind, phone, keys, wallet, lipstick, all accounted for, and headed for the door.

"Hey," Brady called after me. "Text me when you get home safe?"

It was sweet, in a way. Perfunctory, but sweet. "Sure," I lied.

I wouldn't, of course. I never did. I'd learned that those little threads of connection could pull and unravel if you weren't careful. Better to keep things contained, compartmentalized. Brady was Tuesday and Thursday afternoons, sometimes Wednesday if the timing worked. He was hotel rooms and athletic sex and the particular thrill of his hands on me while Owen's contact photo smiled up from my phone screen.

He wasn't someone who needed to know when I got home safe.

The hotel hallway was empty, decorated in that bland corporate style, beige carpet, generic landscape prints, ice machine humming at the far end. I took the elevator down to the lobby, watching the numbers descend: 7, 6, 5, 4. My reflection in the polished metal doors showed me what anyone else

would see: a beautiful young woman in a sundress and leather jacket, maybe meeting friends, maybe visiting family, maybe anything at all.

Certainly not what I actually was. A bad girlfriend.

The lobby was busier, a family checking in, kids running around while their parents dealt with luggage; a businessman on his phone by the window; the desk clerk who'd checked me in two hours ago, carefully not making eye contact now. I walked through like I belonged there, like I had every right, out the automatic doors and into the parking lot where my car waited.

Silver Honda Civic, three years old, nothing special. Owen had helped me buy it, actually, going with me to the dealership, negotiating the price down because he was good at that kind of thing, patient and logical and unwilling to be pressured.

I sat in the driver's seat for a moment before starting the engine, doors locked, windows up, cocooned in the private space of my car. My hands rested on the steering wheel, and I could see faint red marks on my wrists where Brady had gripped them, pinning them above my head against the headboard. They'd fade before Owen saw them. They always did.

I tilted the rearview mirror down to check my face one more time. A tiny smudge of mascara under my left eye, I licked my thumb and wiped it away, watching the black smear disappear. There. Perfect again. I adjusted the mirror back, catching a glimpse of the hotel entrance behind me, half-expecting to see Brady coming out, but of course he wouldn't. He'd probably stay another hour, maybe take a shower, scroll through his phone, bask in the afterglow before heading back to whatever else filled his day.

I wondered if he ever thought about me when we weren't together. Probably not much. Men like Brady didn't need to think about women, we just appeared when wanted, disappeared when not, like some kind of sexual room service.

Which was exactly what made him perfect for me. Confirmation of what you are trumps delusions of what you aren't every time.

I pulled out my phone and opened my messages with Owen again. The cursor blinked impatiently in the text field, waiting. I could tell him I was on my way, but that felt too eager, too much like checking in. Instead, I opened Instagram, scrolled through my feed with my thumb. Jessie had posted photos from her weekend trip to Portland with her boyfriend, the two of them at some trendy brunch spot, making faces at each other over their

lattes. Caption: "My favorite human." with about a dozen heart and coffee emojis.

I double-tapped to like it, not because I cared, but because that's what you did.

Three posts down, Owen's lab partner Derek had shared something about their research team making progress on some protein folding algorithm. Owen was in the background of one photo, slightly out of focus, hunched over a keyboard. He'd been wearing that blue button-down I actually liked, the one that made his eyes look darker.

I didn't like that photo. Didn't want it saved in some algorithm's memory of my activity.

My own Instagram was carefully curated: photos of latte art from the café near our apartment, sunset shots from the climbing gym's outdoor terrace, a selfie from last week where I looked particularly good in golden-hour light. The comments were always the same, fire emojis, "stunning," "gorgeous girl," the occasional "damn" from guys I'd gone to college with. Owen sometimes liked my posts but rarely commented. He'd told me once that he felt weird being obvious about our relationship online, that what we had was private and real and didn't need validation from strangers.

I'd nodded like I understood, like I agreed. Really, I just thought he was naive.

I started the car and pulled out of the parking lot, joined the flow of afternoon traffic. It was 4:47 PM, I'd timed it perfectly. The climbing gym was only twelve minutes from here, fifteen if I hit the light at Morrison badly. I'd swing by there, go inside for exactly six minutes, chat with someone at the front desk, maybe wave at whoever was on the wall, then leave. It would place me there, create the reality of the alibi, give substance to the lie for me as much as for him.

The architecture of deception required this kind of attention to detail. Lies worked better when they were mostly true.

The Morrison light went red, naturally. I stopped behind a white SUV with one of those stick figure family decals on the back window, mom, dad, three kids, a dog, a cat. The daughter figure had a soccer ball, the son a baseball bat. I stared at it while waiting for the light, imagining the woman who'd carefully applied those stickers, proud of her little unit, she collected the complete set. Good for her.

But did she ever fuck someone in hotel rooms on Tuesday afternoons? Did she ever feel the particular electricity of a secret well-kept?

Probably not. Probably she was happy with her stick figure husband and her stick figure life. But wouldn't it be funny if there was a stick figure of another man sort of off a bit to the right?

The thought didn't make me feel superior, exactly. More like separate. Like I was a different species, operating under different rules, subject to different constraints.

The light changed. I pressed the accelerator, felt the car surge forward, and my phone buzzed in the cupholder. I glanced down at a red light two blocks later.

Brady: *You body is amazing. Can't stop thinking about you.*

I felt a flicker of something, not quite pleasure, not quite annoyance, but somewhere in between. He wasn't supposed to do this, the texting afterward, the little breadcrumbs of emotion. This was meant to be simple. Physical. Contained.

But I couldn't exactly tell him that without revealing more than I wanted to reveal.

I typed back: *You're not so bad yourself* with a winky face, then added, *Talk later, busy now*, and put the phone face-down in the cupholder.

The climbing gym appeared on my right, its logo, a stylized mountain peak, visible from the street. I pulled into the parking lot, found a spot near the entrance, and checked the time: 4:53 PM. Perfect.

Inside, the familiar smell hit me immediately: rubber, chalk dust, that specific scent of exertion. Like hard sex. The walls soared up on both sides, covered in colorful holds, people clinging to them at various heights like beautiful, athletic insects. Someone fell from about fifteen feet up, landing on the thick mat with a heavy thump, laughing.

"Hey, Natalie!" The girl at the front desk, Amy, maybe Amanda, waved at me. She was maybe nineteen, perpetually cheerful, with muscular shoulders and her hair in a permanent ponytail.

"Hey!" I called back, all brightness and energy, walking over. "Crazy day, I'm just finishing up. The north wall was brutal."

"I know, right? They just reset it yesterday. Way harder than before."

"Yeah, I definitely felt it," I said, which was true in a sense, my shoulders did ache, though not from climbing.

I lingered at the desk for another minute, asking Amanda, I was pretty sure it was Amanda, about the new route-setting schedule, nodding along as she explained something about the competition team training times changing. I wasn't listening. But I was performing the act of listening: eye contact, interested nods, a small laugh at the right moment when she made some joke about how the setters were "trying to kill us."

"Well, I better get going," I said finally, glancing at my phone like I'd just noticed the time. "My boyfriend's expecting me for dinner."

"Have a good night!" Amanda chirped, already turning to help someone else.

I walked back out into the late afternoon sun, the heat still clinging to the pavement even though it was past five now. In my car, I sat for a moment with the engine running, letting the air conditioning blast. My fingers drummed against the steering wheel, a restless energy I sometimes got after being brutalized by Brady, like my skin was too tight, like I needed to move or scream or do something.

Instead, I pulled out of the parking lot and headed home.

Home. The word felt strange even thinking it. The apartment I shared with Owen, our apartment, with its IKEA furniture and his textbooks stacked on every available surface and the kitchen where we cooked together on weekends, him chopping vegetables with methodical precision while I made whatever sauce or dressing, him explaining some concept from his work that I only half-understood.

The drive took eighteen minutes. I knew because I'd timed it before, multiple times, calculating how long I could stay at the hotel versus how long I needed to maintain the climbing gym story. The math of infidelity was precise if you did it right.

Our building was a three-story complex in a decent neighborhood, nothing fancy but not a shithole either. Owen's salary from the research lab covered most of the rent; I contributed from my job at the marketing agency, though not as much. He'd never made an issue of it. Owen didn't make issues of things. He solved problems, analyzed data, drew conclusions from evidence.

He just apparently needed a lot of evidence.

I grabbed my gym bag from the trunk. I'd learned to actually keep climbing gear in it, shoes and chalk and a water bottle, all authentically used, and headed up the exterior stairs to our second-floor unit. Number

214. There was a welcome mat outside that Owen's mother had given us, something with a geometric pattern that was supposed to be modern and tasteful.

I could hear music through the door before I even unlocked it. Something classical, probably one of the piano concertos Owen liked to play while cooking. He said it helped him think.

The door swung open, and there was the familiar scent of our apartment: the sandalwood candle I'd bought last month, something savory from the kitchen, the faint smell of Owen's cologne that seemed to permeate everything he owned. And there he reliably was, standing at the stove in his gray joggers and a faded t-shirt from some computer science conference, wooden spoon in hand, turning to smile at me as I walked in.

"Hey, you," he said, and his whole face brightened in that way it always did when I came home, like I was the best part of his day.

Something twisted in my chest. Not guilt, exactly. I'd examined that feeling enough times to know it wasn't that. More like... observation. The clinical noting of a reaction I was supposed to have but didn't. Is something wrong with me? You never know yourself, said somebody some time.

"Hey yourself," I said, dropping my bag by the door and shrugging off my leather jacket. "Something smells amazing."

"Panang curry. I got that peanut sauce you like." He set down the spoon and came over, pulling me into a hug, kissing the top of my head. His arms wrapped around me, solid and warm and safe, and I let myself lean into it for a moment.

This was the part that would horrify people if they knew, I thought. Not the hotel room, not Brady's hands all over my body, but this. The way I could come home and slip into this version of myself so easily, so completely. The way I could hug my boyfriend with his smell and his touch still on my skin from two hours ago and feel nothing but a kind of distant curiosity about my own capacity for compartmentalization.

"How was climbing?" Owen asked, pulling back to look at me, his hands still on my waist.

"Good. Hard. They reset the north wall yesterday, so everything's a higher grade now." The lies came so smoothly, each word landing exactly where it should. "My arms are dead."

"I bet." He brushed a strand of hair behind my ear, his fingers gentle. "You want to shower before dinner? I've got maybe fifteen more minutes on

this."

"Yeah, perfect."

I extracted myself from his embrace and headed down the short hallway to our bedroom. Our bed was made. Owen always made the bed, even though I never bothered, with the navy duvet cover we'd picked out together at Target. My jewelry was scattered across the dresser where I'd left it that morning: silver rings, the delicate necklace Owen had given me for our anniversary last year, earrings I'd taken off and forgotten to put away.

I pulled my dress over my head, letting it pool on the floor, and stood there in my underwear, looking at myself in the full-length mirror on the closet door.

My body looked the same as it had in the hotel mirror three hours ago. Same curves, same skin, same face. But the context transformed it entirely. There, I'd been a woman in the aftermath of sex with someone who wasn't her partner. Here, I was Owen's girlfriend, home from the climbing gym, about to shower before dinner.

Both versions were true. Both versions were an illusion. Neither was more real than the other.

I reached behind my back and unhooked my bra, watching my reflection as I did it. Slowly. The way I'd done it for Brady.

No wonder he wanted to smash that.

The shower was hot enough to turn my skin pink. I stood under the spray with my eyes closed, letting the water run over my face, my shoulders, down my back. Steam filled the small bathroom, fogging the mirror, creating a private cloud. I pumped Owen's shampoo into my palm. He used the expensive kind, some organic stuff that smelled like tea tree and mint, and worked it through my hair slowly, methodically.

There was something almost meditative about washing away the evidence. My fingers massaged my scalp in slow circles, and I thought about Brady's hands in my hair, the way he'd gripped it, pulled it. The memory was already fading, becoming indistinct, just another moment filed away in the catalog of moments that Owen would never know about.

I rinsed, watching the soap slide down the drain, and reached for the conditioner.

The thing was, I did love Owen. I'd examined this question from multiple angles, tested it like he might test a hypothesis, and concluded that yes, what I felt for him qualified as love. I loved his mind, the way he could

explain complex concepts with such clarity and patience. I loved how he remembered small things, that I hated cilantro, that I took my coffee with oat milk, that I got anxious before big presentations at work. I loved the way he looked at me, like I was something precious and miraculous.

I loved that he trusted me completely. That especially.

I turned off the water and stepped out, wrapped myself in one of our oversized towels. The mirror was completely fogged. I wiped a circle clear with my hand and stared at my face, dripping, makeup-free. Bare. This was probably the most honest version of myself, stripped down, nothing scripted, and even now I was thinking about how I looked, whether my skin appeared clear enough, whether my eyes seemed bright enough.

The acting never really stopped. I just changed costumes.

I dried off and padded naked into the bedroom, where I pulled on underwear and one of Owen's old t-shirts, this one from MIT, where he'd done his master's. It hung loose on me, almost to mid-thigh. I knew he liked seeing me in his clothes. Most men did. There was something about it that triggered some possessive instinct, seeing their woman branded by their things.

I'd learned to use that.

In the kitchen, Owen had put the curry out, the rice perfectly portioned, everything arranged with the same careful precision he brought to everything. Two glasses of water, ice cubes still square and whole. Napkins folded beside each plate.

"Perfect timing," he said, gesturing to the small table by the window where we ate most of our meals. "How hungry are you? I made extra if you want more."

"This is great." I slid into my chair, picking up my fork. "You're the best, you know that?"

He smiled, that soft, genuine smile that crinkled the corners of his eyes behind his glasses. "I just like taking care of you."

We ate in comfortable silence for a few minutes, the kind of silence that comes from being around someone enough that you don't need to fill every moment with noise. The curry was good, Owen was actually a better cook than I was, more patient with following recipes, more willing to let things simmer properly.

"Oh," he said suddenly, setting down his fork, "I meant to ask, how's that project coming along at work? The one with the difficult client?"

It took me a half-second to remember what he was talking about. The campaign for the boutique hotel chain, the client who kept changing their mind about the brand positioning. I'd complained about it last week over dinner, let Owen problem-solve with me, appreciating his logical approach even though I'd already figured out what I was going to do.

"Better," I said. "I think we're finally aligned on the direction. Meeting on Thursday to present the revised concepts."

"You'll crush it," Owen said with complete confidence. "You always do."

Thursday. I had Brady at one o'clock on Thursday. The meeting was at three-thirty. I'd already planned it out: hotel from one to two-thirty, quick cleanup, drive straight to the client's office downtown, walk in with my presentation deck and my confident smile and no one would ever suspect that seventy-five minutes earlier I'd been in bed with some man pounding the almighty living shit out of me.

The efficiency of it was almost beautiful.

"How's the research going?" I asked, redirecting. This was safer territory. Owen could talk about his work for hours if I let him, and I'd learned to ask just enough questions to seem engaged without needing to truly understand the intricacies of machine learning algorithms or whatever his current focus was.

His face lit up. "Actually, we had a breakthrough today. You know how I was telling you about the problem with the training data?"

I didn't, really, but I nodded.

"Well, Derek suggested we try a different preprocessing approach, and it actually worked. We're seeing a fifteen percent improvement in accuracy, which is huge for this application."

"That's amazing, babe." I reached across the table and squeezed his hand. His fingers intertwined with mine, his thumb rubbing gentle circles on my skin.

"I know it's boring to you," he said, self-deprecating. "All this technical stuff."

"It's not boring. I like hearing about what you're passionate about."

This was true, in its way. I did like it. I liked the sound of his voice when he got excited, the animated way he gestured with his free hand while explaining concepts. I liked being the person he wanted to share these things with.

I just also liked fucking Brady in hotel rooms while Owen sat working in his lab, trusting me completely.

The duality didn't bother me. If anything, it made both experiences sharper, more defined. Light and shadow. You needed both to see the full picture. Ask any artist.

After dinner, we moved to the couch. Owen loaded up Netflix where we were halfway through some documentary series about ocean ecosystems that he'd wanted to watch.

I curled up against Owen's side, my head on his chest, his arm around my shoulders. The documentary narrator droned on about coral bleaching and rising ocean temperatures, images of dying reefs flickering across the screen in blues and grays. Owen's fingers traced absent patterns on my upper arm, slow and rhythmic, and I could feel his breathing, steady and even.

This was nice. I could acknowledge that objectively. This was intimacy, the kind people wrote about in relationship articles and posted about on Instagram with captions about finding your person. The quiet domesticity of a Tuesday night, dinner and a documentary, his heartbeat under my ear.

But I was bored again within ten minutes.

Not with Owen, exactly, but with the stasis of it. The predictability. I knew how this evening would unfold: we'd watch another episode, maybe two. Around nine-thirty, Owen would start getting sleepy, like he always did, his circadian rhythm as reliable as everything else about him. We'd brush our teeth side by side at the bathroom sink, and he'd kiss me goodnight, and we'd have sex maybe, probably, the kind of comfortable sex that came from knowing someone's body well, from established patterns and familiar rhythms.

And it would be fine. Good, even. Owen was attentive, generous, the kind of lover who actually cared whether I came.

But it wouldn't make my pulse race. It wouldn't give me that electrical thrill, that sense of getting away with something, of being bad.

My phone buzzed on the coffee table. I reached for it, careful not to disturb Owen too much.

Brady: *Already counting down to Thursday*

I felt a small spike of irritation. He was texting too much, getting too familiar, crossing the invisible boundaries I'd established. But I couldn't explain those boundaries without revealing why they existed.

I typed back: *Me too* with a smile emoji, then put the phone face-down and settled back against Owen.

"Everything okay?" he asked, his voice slightly muffled by my hair.

"Just questions about Thursday. Jess."

The lie was so automatic I barely registered it. Jessica and I were friendly but not close, the kind of friends who saw each other every few weeks, who texted occasionally but not frequently. She made a perfect cover. Owen had met her a handful of times, knew she existed, but didn't know her well enough to verify details.

"What does she want to do?"

"Oh, nothing specific. She's just thinking ahead." I tilted my head up to look at him. "Is it okay if I make plans on Saturday? I know we usually do stuff together on weekends."

"Of course," Owen said immediately. "You don't need to ask permission, Nat. I want you to have your own life, your own friends."

He meant it. That was the thing about Owen, he wasn't possessive or controlling. He genuinely wanted me to be happy, to have space, to have independence. He'd never once checked my phone, never questioned where I was going or who I was with, never made me feel like I needed to account for my time.

Most women would consider that the greenest of green flags.

I considered it an open door. "You're the best," I said, kissing his jaw. "What did I do to deserve you?"

"I ask myself that question every day," he said, squeezing me closer. "Except reversed."

On the screen, schools of fish scattered from a predator, their silver bodies flashing in synchronized panic. The narrator explained something about survival instincts, about how prey species evolved to detect threats. I watched the predator cut through the water, sleek and purposeful, and felt a strange kinship with it.

The second episode started automatically. Owen shifted slightly, getting more comfortable, and I rearranged myself against him. His hand found mine, our fingers lacing together, and I looked down at our intertwined hands, his longer, slightly callused from his hobby of building mechanical keyboards, mine with the rings I always wore, silver bands on three fingers.

He'd bought me one of them, the one on my right index finger, a simple twisted design. "Saw it and thought of you," he'd said when he gave it to

me, six months ago, no special occasion. Just because.

I still wore it. I'd worn it to the hotel today, actually. Had watched it catch the light while Brady's hands moved over my naked body.

"Hey," Owen said softly, and I realized the episode had ended, the screen now showing the "Are you still watching?" prompt. "You seem far away. You okay?"

I turned to look at him, at his face so close to mine, his eyes concerned behind his glasses, and I manufactured the exact right expression, a little tired, a little contemplative, but warm.

"Just thinking," I said.

"About what?"

"About how lucky I am. This. Us. Coming home to you."

It was what he needed to hear, and it wasn't even entirely untrue. I was lucky. Lucky that he was brilliant but blind in the specific ways that mattered. Lucky that his trust was so complete, so unshakeable. Lucky that I could build this entire shadow life in the spaces between his observations.

He kissed me then, soft and sweet, his hand coming up to cup my face. I kissed him back, putting enough warmth into it to be convincing, enough passion to suggest interest.

"Want to go to bed?" he murmured against my lips.

"Yeah," I said.

We untangled ourselves from the couch. Owen clicked off the TV, checked that the front door was locked, he always checked, part of his systematic nature, while I turned off the lights in the kitchen. The apartment fell into darkness except for the ambient city light filtering through the windows.

In the bedroom, Owen pulled off his shirt, revealing his lean torso. He wasn't built like Brady, no defined abs or sculpted shoulders, but he was attractive in his own way. Narrow-hipped, long-limbed, with that slightly awkward grace of someone who lived mostly in his head.

He caught me looking and smiled, a little self-conscious. "What?"

"Nothing. Just admiring the view," I grinned.

Owen crossed the room to me, his hands finding my waist, sliding up under the MIT t-shirt I was wearing. His t-shirt. His fingers were warm against my skin, tracing the curve of my ribcage, and he looked down at me with that expression I knew so well, desire mixed with something softer, something that looked like reverence.

"You're so beautiful," he said quietly, and there was no lie in it, no line. He meant it the way he meant everything, with complete sincerity.

I reached up and took off his glasses, setting them carefully on the nightstand. He blinked, his eyes adjusting, and I pulled him down to kiss me. His lips were soft, tentative at first, always waiting for me to set the pace, to show him what I wanted.

So different from Brady, who took what he wanted, who moved with confidence and assumption and never checked in with me. He used me.

I deepened the kiss, my hands sliding up his chest, and felt him respond, his breathing changing, his grip on me tightening. He walked me backward toward the bed, and I let him, let myself fall back onto the mattress with him following, his weight settling over me.

His hands pushed the t-shirt up slowly, reverently, and I lifted my arms so he could pull it off completely. He dropped it on the floor beside the bed and just looked at me for a moment, sprawled beneath him in just my underwear, and I watched his face, cataloging his reaction. The slight parting of his lips, the way his pupils dilated, the flush creeping up his neck.

I had this effect on him and I always had. From the first time we'd slept together, two years ago now, after our fifth date, when I'd invited him back to my old apartment and watched him nervously try to figure out if I was actually suggesting what he thought I was suggesting.

He'd been almost apologetically careful that first time, checking in constantly, "Is this okay? Do you like this?", until I'd finally pulled him closer and whispered that yes, it was more than okay, that he could stop asking and just go for it.

Now he knew my body. Knew what made me gasp, where to put his hands, how I liked to be touched. He kissed down my neck, my collarbone, the valley between my breasts, taking his time, building slowly the way he always did.

I closed my eyes and let sensation wash over me, let myself be present in my body. His mouth on my skin, his hands sliding my underwear down my legs, the familiar comfort of our bed beneath me. This was good. This was what I was supposed to want, right?

Owen's hand slid between my thighs, and I made a small sound, arching up into his touch. He made a pleased noise against my shoulder, his fingers moving in the pattern he'd learned I liked, steady and patient.

"I love you," he murmured against my skin, and I felt that familiar twist in my chest again, that odd disconnect between what I should feel and what I actually felt.

"I love you too," I said, and my voice came out breathy, convincing.

He took his time. Owen always took his time, drawing things out, wanting to make sure I was ready, that I was with him. His mouth moved lower, kissing down my stomach, and I threaded my fingers through his hair, letting my head fall back against the pillow. I tried hard not to pull it.

The ceiling above our bed had a water stain in the corner, shaped vaguely like a cloud. I'd noticed it months ago and kept meaning to mention it to the landlord, but I never had. I stared at it now while Owen's mouth moved between my legs, while he used his tongue in that specific way he'd perfected, and I made the sounds I knew he wanted to hear.

It felt good. That was the strange part, it did feel good. My body responded the way it was supposed to, building toward the familiar peak, and when it hit, it was real, genuine, my thighs tightening around his head, my back arching off the bed.

"God," Owen breathed, kissing back up my body, his face flushed and pleased with himself. "You're incredible."

I pulled him up to kiss me, tasting myself on his lips, and reached down to push his joggers and boxers down. He kicked them off awkwardly, nearly falling off the bed in the process, and I laughed, genuinely and unforced, at his gracelessness.

"Smooth," I teased.

"I have my moments," he said, grinning, settling back over me. He reached for the nightstand drawer where we kept condoms, but I stopped his hand.

"Don't need one," I said. "I'm on the pill, remember?"

We'd had this conversation before. Several times, actually. Owen was always careful, always defaulting to extra protection, worried about pregnancy in that logical, risk-assessment way he worried about everything.

"Are you sure?" he asked, hovering above me.

"I'm sure. I want to feel you."

That decided it. He lined himself up and pushed inside slowly, watching my face the whole time. I wrapped my legs around his waist, pulling him deeper. He groaned, his eyes falling closed, and started moving with that steady rhythm, unhurried, thorough.

I matched his pace, my hips rising to meet his, and wrapped my arms around his shoulders. His face was buried in my neck, his breathing harsh and quick against my skin, and I turned my head to press my lips against his temple.

"You feel so good," I whispered, because I knew he needed to hear it, and because it was true enough.

Owen's rhythm stuttered slightly at my words, and he lifted his head to look at me, his eyes intense and unfocused. "Nat," he breathed, just my name, like it meant something.

I pulled him down to kiss me, deep and consuming, and felt him get closer, his movements becoming less controlled, more urgent. I tightened around him deliberately, using my muscles in the way I'd learned drove him crazy, and felt him shudder.

"I'm close," he managed.

"Me too," I lied. "Come inside me."

He did, his whole body going rigid above me, a sound escaping his throat that was half-gasp, half-moan. I held him through it, stroking his back, making soothing noises, and when he finally collapsed beside me, pulling me against his chest, I let myself be held.

"That was..." he started, then trailed off, still catching his breath.

"Yeah," I agreed softly.

We lay there in the darkness, his hand running up and down my spine in lazy strokes. His heartbeat gradually slowed under my ear, returning to its normal rhythm. Outside, I could hear the muffled sounds of the city, a car passing, someone's TV through the thin walls, the distant wail of a siren.

"I should clean up," Owen said eventually, but he didn't move, his arm tightening around me like he couldn't quite bear to let go yet.

"In a minute," I said.

I knew what would happen next because it always happened the same way. In about three minutes, Owen would extract himself, pad to the bathroom, come back with a warm washcloth for me, always thoughtful, always considerate. He'd clean me up gently, dispose of the washcloth, and return to bed. He'd pull me close again, kiss my forehead, and within ten minutes he'd be asleep, his breathing deep and even.

And I'd lie there awake, staring at the water stain on the ceiling, feeling nothing in particular. Feeling no pain.

Right on schedule, Owen stirred. "Be right back," he murmured, kissing my shoulder.

I watched him walk to the bathroom, unselfconscious in his nakedness, and heard the water run. When he came back, he had the washcloth, warm and damp, and he was so careful, so tender, cleaning between my legs with a gentleness that might have been touching if I let it be.

"All good?" he asked, and I nodded.

He disappeared again, and I heard the washcloth hit the hamper, the sound of him washing his hands. When he returned, he slid back into bed and gathered me against him, my back to his chest, his arm draped over my waist.

"Love you," he mumbled, already half-asleep.

"Love you too."

His breathing evened out within minutes, just like I knew it would. I lay very still in his arms, listening to him sleep, feeling the weight of his arm across my stomach, the warmth of his body against my back.

My phone was on the nightstand, face-down, silent. I wondered if Brady had texted again. Probably. He seemed like the type who couldn't leave things alone, who needed constant connection, validation, response.

Owen's phone was there too, charging beside mine. He never locked it. His passcode was my birthday, he'd told me that early on, casual about it, like of course I should have access to everything. I could pick it up right now, scroll through his messages, his emails, his photos, and he'd never know. He'd never even think to check if I had.

The trust was almost insulting in its completeness.

I shifted slightly, and Owen's arm tightened reflexively, pulling me closer even in sleep. His chin rested against the top of my head. We fit together well, physically. His tall frame and my smaller one, puzzle pieces that matched.

I closed my eyes and tried to sleep, but my mind was already moving forward, planning. Thursday afternoon. The hotel again, or maybe somewhere different. Brady had mentioned his roommate would be out of town next week, I'd shut that down immediately, too risky, too many variables. But maybe I could suggest a different location. There was that boutique hotel downtown, the one with the rooftop bar. More expensive, but also more exciting. More anonymous.

And after, I'd go to my client meeting, and I'd be brilliant, and I'd come home to Owen, and he'd ask how it went, and I'd tell him it went perfectly, and he'd be proud of me, and we'd order dinner or cook together, and the cycle would continue.

Perfect. Sustainable. Indefinitely.

I must have dozed eventually because I woke to gray morning light filtering through the curtains and Owen's alarm buzzing softly on his nightstand. He stirred behind me, reaching over to silence it, and I felt him press a kiss to my bare shoulder.

"Morning," he said, his voice rough with sleep.

"Morning," I echoed, rolling over to face him.

His hair was sticking up on one side, flattened on the other where he'd slept on it. His eyes were squinty without his glasses, and there was a crease on his cheek from the pillowcase. He looked young and rumpled and utterly unguarded.

"I have an early meeting," he said apologetically. "But I can make coffee before I go?"

"You're perfect."

He kissed me, morning breath and all, and climbed out of bed. I watched him pull on clean boxers and the pants from yesterday, a fresh shirt from the closet. He found his glasses and put them on, transforming back into his public self, and headed for the kitchen.

I lay in bed for another few minutes, listening to him move around the apartment, the coffee grinder, the click of the espresso machine, the clink of mugs. The familiar morning symphony of our life together.

My phone showed three new messages. One from my boss about a meeting time change. One from Jessica, actually, asking if I wanted to grab drinks next week. And one from Brady, sent at eleven forty-seven last night: *Sweet dreams beautiful*

I deleted Brady's message and responded to Jessica: *Yes! Tuesday or Wednesday work for me?*

Then I got up, found Owen's MIT shirt from last night on the floor, and pulled it back on. In the kitchen, Owen had already made my coffee, oat milk, no sugar, exactly how I liked it, and was pouring his own.

"You're my favorite person," I said, accepting the mug and kissing his cheek.

"Right back at you," he said, smiling that soft smile that made his eyes crinkle.